Stan Wawrinka Says Goodbye After a 23-Year Tennis Career

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Stan Wawrinka has always known how to stir a crowd, and that did not change in the final tour-level match of his career. The 41-year-old Swiss star lost to Czech opponent Jiri Lehecka in front of passionate home support in Basel on Tuesday, but he left showing the **hallmarks** of a career that exceeded expectations.

There was the stylish one-handed **backhand** down the line, the finger pointing to his temple, and the demand for more noise from the stands. There was the roar of "Allez!" after winning a point he probably should not have won. And there were tears, too, as Wawrinka, his family, and his team took in the reality of an **honourable** 7-5, 7-6 (7-2) defeat.

The loss brought an end to a professional career spanning 23 years, 985 matches, and three Grand Slam titles. Wawrinka, a former world number three, told the ATP website that all he wanted was to give everything, have no regrets, and always fight and give 100 percent in every match, out of respect for himself, his opponent, the tournament, and the fans.

So many talented players of his generation felt that Roger Federer, Rafael Nadal, and Novak Djokovic, known as the 'Big Three,' were a **blockade** preventing them from becoming a Grand Slam champion. It did not stop Wawrinka. With explosive shot-making and relentless **endurance**, he barrelled past the trio on his way to winning his three major titles.

His career had been ticking along steadily until he lifted one of the sport's biggest prizes at the age of 28. At the 2015 French Open, he beat Federer in the **quarter-finals**, then beat Djokovic in the final.

Word Treasure

backhand -- A shot in tennis hit with the back of the hand facing forward.

hallmarks -- Typical signs that show what something or someone is really like.

honourable -- Deserving respect because it is honest and fair.

blockade -- Something that blocks the way and stops others from getting through.

endurance -- The ability to keep going through something long and difficult.

quarter-finals -- The round in a contest before the semi-finals, with eight players or teams left.

Background you need

In professional tennis, players travel to tournaments and are ranked by their results over a season.

A Grand Slam title is one of the sport's biggest prizes, won by beating strong players through several rounds.

A long career means staying fit and competitive for many seasons, even as new rivals arrive.

Wawrinka played through a generation led by three very strong rivals, so winning a major title meant beating some of the best players of his time.

Break it down

LEAD: Stan Wawrinka's final tour-level match ends a 23-year tennis career

KEY EVENT: Loss to Jiri Lehecka in Basel

+- WHO: Stan Wawrinka, 41, and Czech opponent Jiri Lehecka

+- WHEN AND WHERE: Tuesday, in Basel, before passionate home support

+- SCORE: 7-5, 7-6 (7-2)

+- MOMENT: A stylish backhand, a finger to his temple, crowd noise, and tears with family and team

CAREER: 985 matches and three Grand Slam titles

+- WHAT HE SAID: Give everything, have no regrets, and give 100 percent in every match, out of respect for himself, his opponent, the tournament, and the fans

+- BIG THREE: Federer, Nadal, and Djokovic were felt to block other players, but did not stop Wawrinka

EVIDENCE: At the 2015 French Open, Wawrinka beat Federer in the quarter-finals and Djokovic in the final

Why it matters

Wawrinka's farewell shows that persistence and full effort can carry a player past even the strongest rivals, and that a long career can be honoured even in defeat.

Test what you remember

1. **Who did Stan Wawrinka lose to in his final tour-level match?**
   - (A) Rafael Nadal
   - (B) Roger Federer
   - (C) Jiri Lehecka
   - (D) Novak Djokovic
2. **What was the score of Wawrinka's final tour-level match?**
   - (A) 7-6, 6-4
   - (B) 7-5, 7-6 (7-2)
   - (C) 6-4, 6-3
   - (D) 6-2, 6-2
3. **How many Grand Slam titles did Wawrinka win in his career?**
   - (A) Two
   - (B) One
   - (C) Five
   - (D) Three
4. **How long did Wawrinka's professional career last?**
   - (A) 15 years
   - (B) 20 years
   - (C) 23 years
   - (D) 28 years
5. **At the 2015 French Open, whom did Wawrinka beat in the final?**
   - (A) Rafael Nadal
   - (B) Roger Federer
   - (C) Novak Djokovic
   - (D) Jiri Lehecka
6. **What did Wawrinka tell the ATP website he wanted in every match?**
   - (A) To win quickly
   - (B) To play only at home
   - (C) To avoid strong opponents
   - (D) To give everything, have no regrets, and give 100 percent

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: C 2: B 3: D 4: C 5: C 6: D

Questions to think about

1. Stan Wawrinka: He told the ATP website that all he wanted was to give everything, have no regrets, and always fight and give 100 percent in every match, out of respect for himself, his opponent, the tournament, and the fans.

2. Many talented players of his generation: They felt that Federer, Nadal, and Djokovic, known as the 'Big Three,' were a blockade preventing them from becoming a Grand Slam champion.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):